

The brain

This band of nerve fibers connects the left and right sides of the cerebrum.

Locked safely within your skull is your brain, the headquarters of the nervous system and the control center of your body. Inside the brain, billions of nerve cells sort and store incoming messages, and send out the instructions that keep your body working normally. These cells are also responsible for the way that you think and remember things, and your imagination.

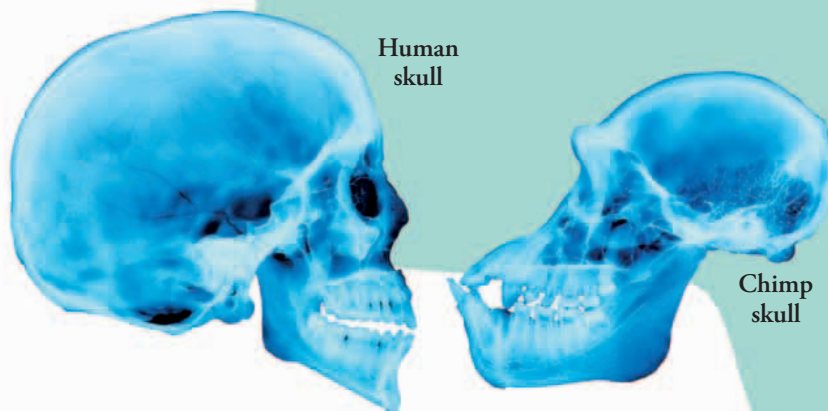
GROOVES AND WRINKLES

The largest part of the brain is the cerebrum. It is divided into left and right halves by a long, deep groove. Smaller grooves and folds cover the cerebrum's surface. The wrinkles created by these folds increase the cerebrum's surface—allowing more thinking power to be packed inside the skull.



BIG BRAINS

The human brain is four times heavier than a chimp's (our closest relative). The human skull is also much larger, but it is still a very tight squeeze—the cerebrum takes up 85 percent of the space. A chimp's brain is less wrinkly, but shares many of the same structures.



Human skull

Chimp skull

INSIDE THE BRAIN

Slicing down the center of the brain reveals its three main parts: the cerebrum, the cerebellum, and the brain stem. The cerebrum is the most powerful part of your brain, responsible for all your conscious actions, speech, and feelings. The smaller cerebellum coordinates your movements and balance. The brain stem connects the brain to the spinal cord and controls your reflexes and basic functions, such as heart rate and blood flow.

